

Salary Negotiation Scripts: Word-for-Word for Every Situation

RenWork Digital Products

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Negotiation is not a battle; it is a structured conversation designed to align value with compensation. The following scripts are engineered to remove the anxiety of the "ask," replacing it with professional clarity. Each script follows a four-part architecture: the ****Opening Line**** (setting the tone), the ****Pivot**** (reframing the context), the ****Ask**** (the specific request), and ****Objection Handling**** (maintaining composure when pushed back). Use these verbatim, adjusting only the bracketed data points.

1. Responding to an Initial Job Offer

****Context:**** You have received a verbal or written offer. Do not accept immediately. Buy time to negotiate.

****Opening Line:****

"Thank you so much for this offer. I'm thrilled about the opportunity to join [Company Name] and contribute to the [Specific Team/Project]. I've been processing the details, and I have a few questions regarding the compensation structure before I make my final decision."

****The Pivot:****

"I've reviewed the numbers, and while I am excited about the role, the initial figure of [Current Offer] is slightly below the market range for this level of responsibility, particularly given my [Specific Skill/Experience] which will allow me to hit the ground running."

****The Ask:****

"Based on my research and the value I bring, I would like to discuss adjusting the base salary to [Target Salary]. Is there flexibility in the number to get us to that point?"

****Objection Handling:****

* *If they say, "We have a fixed budget band":* "I understand budget constraints are real. If the base salary is capped, could we look at a signing bonus or a guaranteed performance review after

90 days that adjusts the base salary to [Target Salary] if I meet [Specific KPI]?"

* *If they say, "We can't move on the number":* "I appreciate your transparency. If the number is truly immovable, what other elements of the package--such as remote work flexibility, additional PTO, or professional development budgets--could be adjusted to help close the gap?"

2. Counter-Offering Without Sounding Greedy

****Context:**** You are pushing back on a number that feels low, but you want to preserve the relationship.

****Opening Line:****

"I really value this role and the team culture here. I'm confident I can deliver significant results for [Company Name], which is why I want to ensure our compensation structure reflects that mutual investment."

****The Pivot:****

"Looking at the total compensation package, I believe there is a gap between the current offer and the market standard for professionals with my background in [Specific Field]. I don't want to start this relationship with a disparity in value perception."

****The Ask:****

"I would like to propose a counter-offer of [Target Salary]. This figure aligns with recent market data for roles of this scope and reflects the immediate impact I plan to make in my first year."

****Objection Handling:****

* *If they say, "Is that a hard number?":* "It's a target number based on market data. I'm open to discussing how we can bridge the gap between your current offer and this figure, whether through base salary, equity, or other benefits."

* *If they say, "We usually pay new hires lower to start":* "I understand the standard practice, but given my [Specific Achievement or Unique Skill], I believe I can bypass the typical learning curve. Would you be open to a higher starting salary to reflect this accelerated value, or a structured step-in raise after six months?"

3. Asking for a Raise Mid-Year

****Context:**** You have been with the company for at least six months and have exceeded expectations.

****Opening Line:****

"Thanks for making time to meet. I wanted to discuss my current role and my recent contributions to the team, specifically regarding [Project A] and [Project B]."

****The Pivot:****

"Since my last compensation review, my scope has expanded to include [New Responsibility], and I've successfully [Specific Metric, e.g., increased revenue by 15% or reduced costs by \$10k]. These results have directly impacted our quarterly goals."

****The Ask:****

"In light of this expanded scope and demonstrated impact, I would like to request a salary adjustment to [Target Salary]. This brings my compensation in line with my current level of responsibility and market value."

****Objection Handling:****

* *If they say, "Raises are only given at annual review":* "I understand the standard cycle, but my role has fundamentally changed since my last review. Could we look at an exception to this rule, or perhaps a bonus to bridge the gap until the next annual cycle?"

* *If they say, "We don't have budget for it right now":* "That's fair. If immediate budget isn't available, can we set a specific date to revisit this when Q3 budgets are approved? I'd like to have a concrete plan in place for when my compensation aligns with my current output."

4. Negotiating Freelance Project Rates

****Context:**** A client is questioning your rate card or asking for a discount.

****Opening Line:****

"I appreciate you sharing the project brief. I'm confident I can deliver the high-quality work you're looking for for [Project Name]."

****The Pivot:****

"My rates reflect not just the hours spent, but the specific expertise and speed I bring to the

table. By working with me, you're gaining access to [Specific Niche Skill] that reduces your overall risk and timeline."

****The Ask:****

"For this project, I will be charging [Rate/Total Fee]. This includes [Deliverable 1] and [Deliverable 2], with a standard revision policy of two rounds. Does this structure work for your budget?"

****Objection Handling:****

- * If they say, "Can you do it for less?":* "I can't lower my rate, as it's calibrated for the quality and speed I provide. However, if budget is a strict constraint, I can offer a scoped-down version of the project that focuses only on [Core Deliverable], which would cost [Lower Fee]."

- * If they say, "Other freelancers quoted lower":* "I'm glad you have options. I believe my value lies in [Specific Differentiator, e.g., strategic insight or error-free execution], which prevents costly rework later. I'm confident the investment in my rate will yield a better long-term return for your brand."

5. Asking for Equity

****Context:**** You are joining a startup or early-stage company where cash is limited.

****Opening Line:****

"I'm excited about the mission of [Company Name] and the potential for growth here. I'm looking for a compensation package that aligns my interests with the long-term success of the company."

****The Pivot:****

"While I understand the current cash constraints, I am seeking a stake in the upside. I want to ensure that my financial rewards are tied to the company's valuation growth, which is where I believe my [Specific Skill] will have the most impact."

****The Ask:****

"I would like to negotiate for [X]% equity, with a standard four-year vesting schedule and a one-year cliff. This structure ensures I'm fully committed to the company's success over the long term."

****Objection Handling:****

- * If they say, "We don't usually give equity to this level":* "I understand policy, but given my role in [Critical Function, e.g., scaling sales or building the core product], I believe equity is a fair component to incentivize high performance. Could we discuss a modest equity grant to

align

us?"

* *If they say, "The pool is almost depleted":* "That's a common challenge. Could we look at a fresh pool issue or a smaller percentage with a higher strike price? I'm flexible on the structure as long as there is a meaningful upside potential."

6. Negotiating Benefits and PTO

****Context:**** The salary is fixed, but you need flexibility or additional perks.

****Opening Line:****

"The base salary is within my expected range, so I'm feeling good about that part of the offer. I'd like to discuss the flexibility and benefits components to ensure the overall package supports my productivity and well-being."

****The Pivot:****

"I work best in environments that offer autonomy and trust. Having additional resources for [Specific Need, e.g., remote work gear, health, or time off] allows me to focus deeply on delivering high-quality work without burnout."

****The Ask:****

"Could we add [Specific Benefit, e.g., 5 extra days of PTO, a home office stipend of \$500, or a professional development budget of \$2,000/year] to the offer? This would make the package significantly more attractive to me."

****Objection Handling:****

* *If they say, "PTO is fixed at 15 days":* "I understand. If additional PTO isn't possible, could we offer a flexible start/end time policy, or the ability to work from home three days a week? This flexibility would be a major plus for me."

* *If they say, "We can't increase the benefits budget":* "If the budget is locked, could we look